

nation HYDERABAD BLASTS

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There's a tragic familiarity to the scene of the serial blasts—the shattered remains of men, women and children, the belated arrival of the police amid reports that warning signals were ignored, and then the procession of politicians from the Centre and the state vowing to step up security. Coming barely 100 days after a bomb killed nine in the Mecca Masjid in the old city, the blasts in a popular public park and an equally popular eatery in Hyderabad last week killed 41, including 11 Muslims, and left 60 injured. The death toll would have been higher had it not been for the intermittent rain that made many stay away from the 2,200-seat laser show arena at Lumbini Park. Besides, a bomb placed under a bridge was fortuitously discovered and defused. The police have released the sketch of a 25-year-old man suspected of carrying out the attack at Lumbini Park.

That the attacks were a tragedy foretold is worrying. Intelligence alerts

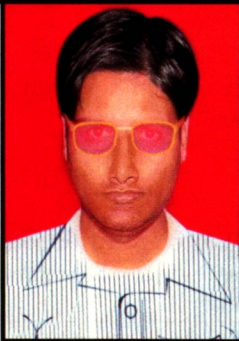


THE PAK-BANGLA AXIS OF

New trends emerge from the debris of the serial blasts. Even as evidence points to the involvement of

by Central government agencies had warned of terror during the run-up to the Ramzan and Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations, hinting at the prospect of two foreign-trained operatives setting off explosions at crowded places. But the state police did not seem to have had the slightest clue about the jihadis.

The city known for its IT industry now finds itself, with frightening regularity, on the terror map. Security analysts point out that Pakistani jihadi organisations look upon Hyderabad as a Muslim land historically belonging to the ummah, which needs to be 'liberated' from the control of non-Muslims.



CLUE BLUES: Remains of the eatery (above); a sketch of the suspect

Since 1995, they have been systematically setting up sleeper cells in the local Muslim community. With the near-absence of strife in the city for 15 years, they thought communal passions could be fomented only by stepping up the

terror drive. Though one in every five of its residents is Muslim, Hyderabad had lost its distinct Islamic identity with modernisation and expansion. The jihadis exploited the economic divide. The poor Muslims in Nalgonda, Mahbubnagar and Warangal, who did not benefit from the economic boom,

felt they should extend subversive help to those who talked of jihad. The city thus emerged as the headquarters of the pro-jihadis in south India, providing logistics and other support for terror strikes.

The narco-analysis done on Sameer, one of the accused in the Mecca Masjid blast, has pointed to increasing militant interest in south India, owing to the intensification of army patrolling on the India-Pakistan border and the extra vigil in bigger metros like Delhi. It also reveals that the militants are now being trained in Bangladesh. Intelligence sources say Pakistan is not only intensifying its attack on the Indian hinterland, but is also using organisations like the Harkat-ul-Jihad-al-Islami (HUJI), consisting primarily of Indians and